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Yes, a California bill would ban chemicals found in Skittles and other foods - California is considering a ban on the sale and manufacturing of food products that contain five common additives.

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In 2022, Europe from being used in food. The decision sparked conversations in the U.S. about potentially harmful health effects of the chemical, which is used in , coffee creamer and cake icing.

Now, some claim California is considering its own ban on titanium dioxide, red dye No. 3 and other chemicals commonly used in food products.

VERIFY reader Gabrielle also asked if a proposed bill in the state would ban the use of titanium dioxide and four other food additives.

THE QUESTION

Would a California bill ban chemicals found in Skittles and other foods in the state?

THE SOURCES

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* Ingredients lists for Skittles, Pez and Hot Tamales candies

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THE ANSWER

Yes, a California bill would ban chemicals found in Skittles and other foods in the state.

WHAT WE FOUND

If passed, would ban five common food additives: titanium dioxide, red dye No. 3, brominated vegetable oil, potassium bromate and propylparaben.

The proposed legislation prohibits any person or entity from manufacturing or selling a food product that contains any of the five chemicals.

California Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Woodland Hills), who introduced the bill, that California would be the first state in the nation to ban the five food additives. The ban would take effect on Jan. 1, 2025, if the bill is passed into law.

Violators would be subject to a fine of up to $5,000 for their first offense and a fine of up to $10,000 for any subsequent offenses, according to the bill text. The state attorney general, a city attorney, a county counsel or a district attorney could bring action to enforce the law.

Two California Assembly committees have passed the bill as of April 28, but it has not yet become law.

A spokesperson for Gabriel said the bill has been referred to the Assembly Appropriations Committee. If it passes there, it would head to the Assembly Floor next. The bill would then go to various Senate committees, the Senate Floor and finally Gov. Gavin Newsom's desk.

Titanium dioxide, potassium bromate, propylparaben, brominated vegetable oil, and a handful of artificial colors are banned in the European Union over concerns that they could be harmful to human health, .

More from VERIFY:

Here's a breakdown of the five food additives that could be banned if the California bill passes.

Titanium dioxide

is used to enhance the color and sheen of certain foods. That includes some popular candies .

In Skittles, titanium dioxide is likely used as a primer to help the candy's colorful hues stick, Kelly Johnson-Arbor, M.D., the medical director at the National Capital Poison Center, said.

Though have classified titanium dioxide as a potential human carcinogen, it is safe for use in foods or food coloring as long as the quantity doesn't exceed 1% of the total weight of the food.

Norbert Kaminski, Ph.D., the director of Michigan State University's Center for Research on Ingredient Safety, previously told VERIFY that the current studies on titanium dioxide exposure have been limited to animals.

Red dye No. 3

Red dye No. 3, , is used as a red coloring in some foods. Some popular candies, such as and , and other food products contain the additive.

Red dye No. 3 is . But it has been based on a potential link to cancer in animals.

that synthetic food dyes, such as red dye No. 3, can cause hyperactivity and other neurobehavioral issues in children.

Brominated vegetable oil

, brominated vegetable oil is a food additive that can be used to keep citrus flavoring from separating in sodas and other beverages.

Health concerns about brominated vegetable oil stem from the ingredient bromine, which can irritate the skin and mucous membranes, dietitian Katherine Zeratasky wrote for the Mayo Clinic. Long-term exposure to bromine can cause headaches, memory loss, and impaired balance or coordination.

There have been reports of people experiencing memory loss, along with skin and nerve problems, after drinking "excessive amounts" of soda containing brominated vegetable oil, Zeratsky says.

The use of brominated vegetable oil is allowed in "small amounts," .

Potassium bromate

Potassium bromate is an oxidizing agent that improves dough, . It's used to make bread and other baked goods, but only limited amounts of the additive remain in products that are properly baked and heated.

The FDA as a food additive, and allows specific amounts of it in flour and baked goods.

Studies have shown that "significant doses" of potassium bromate given to rodents can cause cancer, and harm cells and DNA. But "humans don't regularly consume potassium bromate at the doses and exposure levels that lead to adverse health outcomes in rodents," according to Michigan State University's Center for Research on Ingredient Safety.

"Current research shows that potassium bromate doesn't cause harm in humans when consumed in properly heated baked goods and bread at normal levels," the Michigan State University center says.

Propylparaben

Parabens, including propylparaben, are commonly used in small amounts as preservatives in cosmetics, pharmaceuticals, food and beverages, .

that parabens affect hormone function and the .

its scientists "continue to review published studies on the safety of parabens," but the agency does not have information showing they have an adverse effect on human health.

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